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Gabriel feels confident in 45th

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Contentious national elections are heating up as Nov. 3 draws near, which makes it easy to overlook the quieter campaigns being run by local office seekers.

Two candidates are running to represent the 45th Assembly District, which comprises Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Bell Canyon, Canoga Park and Woodland Hills among other communities. Democratic incumbent Jesse Gabriel, who was elected to the office in 2018, hopes to fend off Republican challenger Jeffi Girgenti, a manicurist from Woodland Hills.

Gabriel's first term in office was met with unexpected challenges.

"We're facing a once-in-a-century global health crisis, an economic crisis. The state has a budget crisis. We're at this unprecedented moment of national conversation about race and justice and policing, and that's all on top of wildfires and homelessness and challenges with our public education system," Gabriel said.

"I've done more than I expected in my first term, but I also feel like this is a really important moment to be at the table and help make some of the decisions that are going to make life better for folks in our community."

Gabriel is relying on his first-term record and incumbent status to make up for his inability to meet constituents face-to-face. He hasn't gone door-to-door or done other forms of campaigning that could pose a health risk. Instead, he's been participating in virtual events and using social media to connect with residents.

"My theory on this is, if you work really hard, do the right thing and you're motivated to serve the community, to get the policy right, the politics will take care of itself. For me, the No. 1 reelection strategy from the day I was elected was to just do my job really well," Gabriel said.

Gabriel's challenger, Jeffi Girgenti, said she never planned to get into politics, but that her clients at her Woodland Hills salon, the Nail Cafe, often told her she should consider running for office.

Girgenti decided to run last year when she was signing a petition to recall Gov. Gavin Newsom and spoke to state Senate candidate Houman Salem. Until that point, Girgenti had been registered as an independent, but Salem convinced her to register as a Republican.

"He told me there were (Democratic candidates) running unopposed and that as a business owner I'd make a good candidate. I registered as a Republican. I was a write-in candidate (in the primary)—I got 951 write-ins, which was twice the amount of anyone running in L.A. County," she said.

One of the main issues Girgenti is running on is repealing Assembly Bill 5, the new 2020 law that requires independent contractors to be considered full-time employees with benefits.

Girgenti said the law will impact her nail salon business in which many of her workers are considered independent contractors.

"They've unemployed easily one million people across California and there's no end in sight. They want to do it nationally. Repealing AB 5 is going to be a huge, huge thing we have to do," Girgenti said.

"(The law) directly impacts me as a manicurist. Unless you have enough money to hire lobbyists to create

exemptions, then you're kind of screwed. All those exemptions have expiration dates, so we're all going to be screwed anyway."

Girgenti, the daughter of a police officer, said she'd also like to make reforms to law enforcement but doesn't believe that defunding the police is the way to go.

She says she has a plan to create a program that will enroll officers with bachelor's degrees in psychology into a master's program so they can learn how to defuse situations without resorting to violence. She'd also like to see a program wherein social workers can receive a modicum of police training so they can help officers respond to calls and have the proper training to protect themselves.

As a first-time candidate, Girgenti is facing an uphill battle in informing voters about who she is and what she stands for, especially in the midst of the pandemic, which has shut down traditional forms of campaigning. She said that wherever she goes she hands out cards detailing where she stands on the issues. She's hosted small events at her campaign office and is using social media to get her name out.

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